

Atractaspis engaddensis

Atractaspis engaddensis, also known as the **Israeli mole viper**^{[3][4][5][6]} or "أسود خبيث" (in Arabic, pronounced "Aswad Khabith") or "שרף עין גדי" and "צפעון שחור"^[7] (in Hebrew, pronounced "Saraf Ein Gedi" and "Tzifon Shachor") is a venomous snake found in Egypt (Sinai Peninsula), Israel, Jordan, and Saudi Arabia.^[1] The specific epithet references the type locality, Ein Gedi on the western shore of the Dead Sea.^[8]

Description

It is an extremely venomous and dangerous snake native to the Middle East. Its body is usually dark black in color and it has small eyes with round pupils. The head and the tail are short and pointy, which makes it harder even for veterans to distinguish head from tail. Its approximate size is 60–80 cm. As a defense it rolls with its tail up and its head hidden under its body.

This snake is active mainly at night, and is found in arid or semi-arid desert areas. It dwells in underground burrows (hence the name "mole viper" or "burrowing asp"), is found under rocks, and is seen basking on roads on warm nights. Although its main habitat is in the desert, it is found in desert oases, around streams and springs rich in vegetation, and apparently it needs this moisture. Sometimes it enters human settlements.

The mating of this snake occurs in the months of July–August, this late period of mating relative to other snakes may indicate its tropical origin. From the end of September until November, 2–3 eggs, about 75 millimeters long, are laid in a humid environment that is essential for the development of the embryos. The elongated eggs are large relative to the dimensions of the black viper and relative to snakes in general. The young hatch after about 3 months when they are equipped with a venom system like their parents.^[9]

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Conservation status



Least Concern (IUCN 3.1)^[1]

Scientific classification

Kingdom:	<u>Animalia</u>
Phylum:	<u>Chordata</u>
Class:	<u>Reptilia</u>
Order:	<u>Squamata</u>
Suborder:	<u>Serpentes</u>
Family:	<u>Atractaspididae</u>
Genus:	<u><i>Atractaspis</i></u>
Species:	<i>A. engaddensis</i>

Binomial name

Atractaspis engaddensis

Haas, 1950^[2]